

Unusual entrepreneurs TRAILBLAZERS

ALOK
JALAN



MANDAR DEODHAR

first MILESTONE

Buying their first three hoardings in Mumbai in 2001

strong DESIRE

The Mumbai University graduate wants good quality street furniture

eyeing the FUTURE

Aims at being the biggest and the best in his business

ADDING IT ALL UP

He is the man behind advertising screens that stare at you even as you feast on dimsums at a restaurant, head towards your office in an elevator or get a pedicure at a salon. Laqshya Media's digital screens flood you with advertising you cannot escape. The 11-year-old company has transformed Out Of Home (OOH) advertising by introducing digital screens and interactive projection systems. "The future of advertising is in the use of technology. If you want to stand out, you must innovate and give your customers something extra, which we do," says Alok Jalan, managing director of Laqshya. With 10,000 advertising panels, digital screens, Bluetooth-enabled displays across India, Laqshya is one of the leading OOH companies in the country. It was

36, ADVERTISING PIONEER

MD. LAQSHYA MEDIA

OUTDOOR PRESENCE IN 2001: 3 hoardings

CURRENT PRESENCE: 10,000 display panels

born in 1997 from a tiny office at Andheri, Mumbai, when Alok, 36, and his younger brother Anup, 34, decided to offer advertisers a single entity that could handle a nationwide campaign. "We identified that there was no single point where advertisers could go for a pan-India outdoor campaign. And we encashed it," says Jalan, a commerce graduate from the University of Mumbai who quit his family's textile export business to "dream big". Anup, working with an advertising agency, brought in industry knowledge and Laqshya kicked off with hoardings for Samsung, Konica, LG and Discovery channel. The first major milestone came in 2001 when Laqshya bought its first three hoardings in Mumbai. Soon enough they had big budget clients like UTI Mutual Fund, HDFC, Shoppers' Stop and Diageo.

In 2000, Laqshya moved from hand-painted hoardings to digital printing. It expanded operations to Dubai and Sri Lanka and signed a private-public-partnership (PPP) to design, erect and operate 1,000 air-conditioned bus shelters in Dubai through its subsidiary, Right Angle Media. The growth of their business saw Anup move his base to Dubai and their PPP model attracted \$10 million in private equity funding from UTI Ventures and another \$68 million from Warburg Pincus. Alok pursued his urban infrastructure dream in India with a foot-over-bridge in Indore, for which he got exclusive advertising rights from Metlife Insurance. At Hyderabad's Greenfield Airport, Laqshya custom-designed digital advertising screens that match the temple-leaf design of the airport. Driving down to his office in a Skoda Laura from his Andheri home, Alok often notes the need for street furniture such as taxi shelters and automated toilets. Laqshya has also designed interactive projection systems for Babool bubble gum, digital screens where audiences can choose an advertisement, and is set to deploy Bluetooth-enabled displays in malls. His swanky office has a specialised research team to stay ahead of competition. "We want to become the biggest and the best in the business. After all, that's what our company name suggests," says Alok. Not difficult to achieve yet another *laqshya*.

by Aditi Pai